

Math 114 Class notes Fall 2026

To accompany
Precalculus 2e
by *Abramson*

Peter Westerbaan

Last updated: September 22, 2026

Table Of Contents

Unit 1 1

1.1: Functions and Function Notation 1

1.2: Domain and Range 6

1.3: Rates of Change and Behavior of Graphs 11

1.4: Composition of Functions 18

1.5: Transformation of Functions 20

1.6: Absolute Value Functions 28

2.1: Linear Functions 31

2.2: Graphs of Linear Functions 35

2.3: Modeling with Linear Functions 39

Unit 2 42

3.1: Complex Numbers 42

3.2: Quadratic functions 49

3.3: Power Functions and Polynomial Functions 53

Math 114 Formula Sheet

Unit One

Fractional exponents:

$$x^{a/b} = \sqrt[b]{x^a}$$

Subtracting exponents:

$$x^{a-b} = \frac{x^a}{x^b}$$

Average Rate of Change:

$$\frac{f(b) - f(a)}{b - a}$$

Slope of a Line:

$$m = \frac{y_2 - y_1}{x_2 - x_1}$$

Point-Slope form:

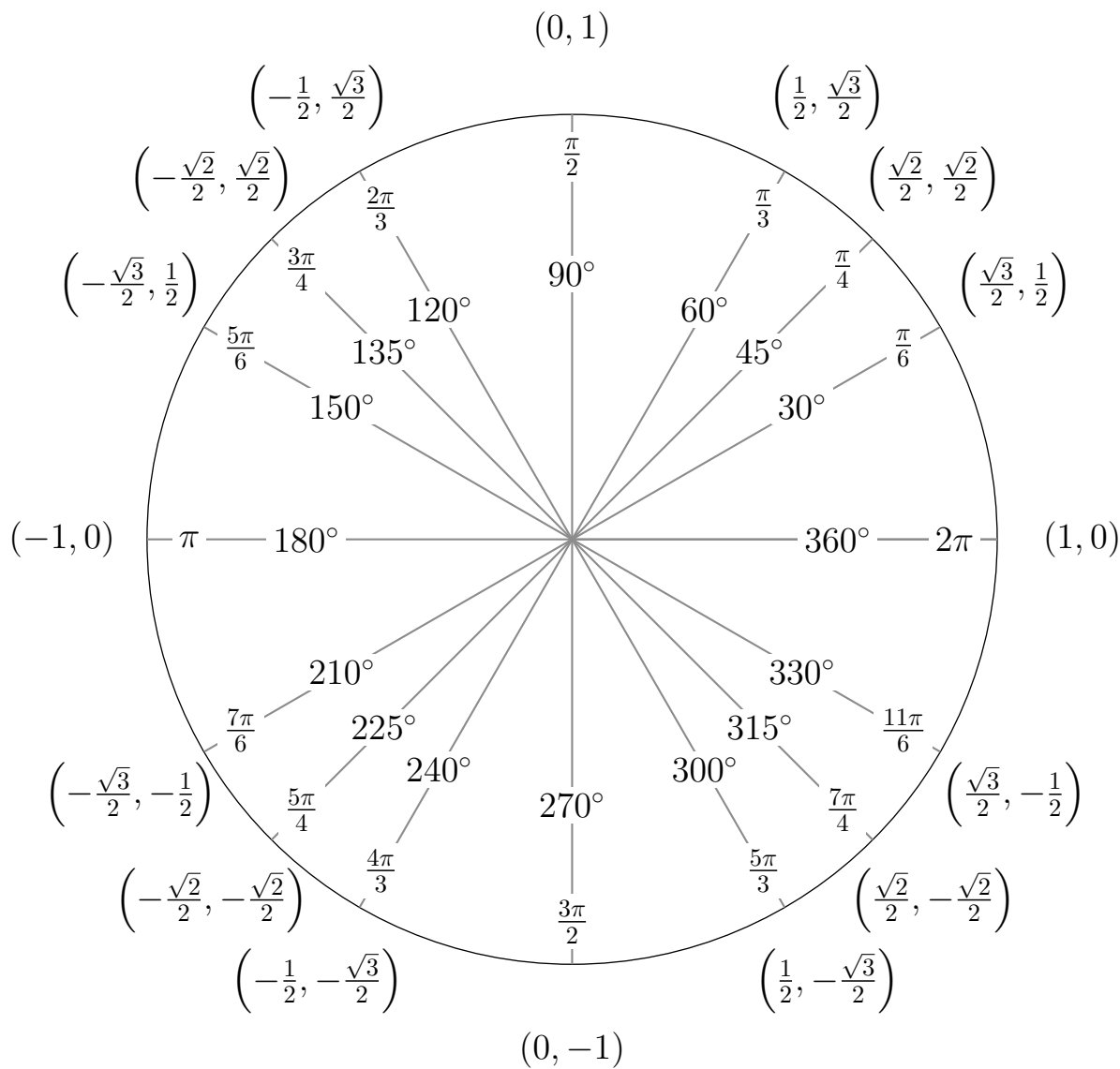
$$y - y_1 = m(x - x_1)$$

Slope-Intercept form:

$$y = mx + b$$

Unit Circle

$$(\cos(\theta), \sin(\theta))$$



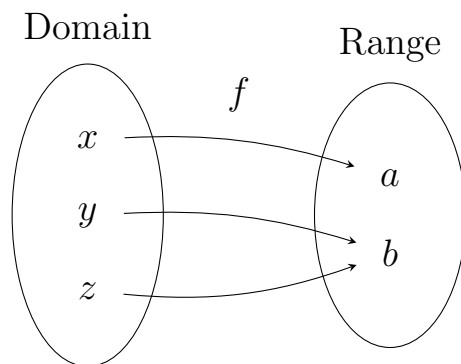
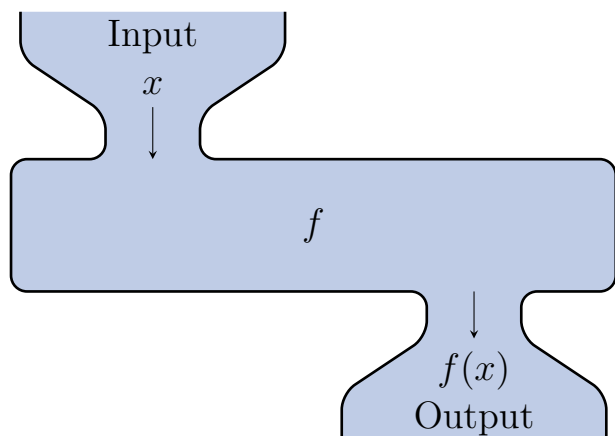
$$180^\circ = \pi \text{ rad}$$

1.1: Functions and Function Notation

Definition.

A **function** is a relation in which each possible input value leads to exactly one output value.

The input values make up the **domain**, and the output values make up the **range**.



Example. Let $f(x) = 2x^2 - 2x + 1$. Evaluate the following

$$f(1)$$

$$f(-2)$$

$$f(a)$$

$$f(a + h)$$

$$\frac{f(a + h) - f(a)}{h}$$

Example. Suppose that the following tables represent a carnival truck’s menu prices. Which table would represent a valid function?

Item	Price
Funnel cake	\$8
Chicken strips	\$9
Ribbon fries	\$7
Cheese nachos	\$6

Item	Price
Funnel cake	\$8
Chicken strips	\$8
Ribbon fries	\$7
Cheese nachos	\$6

Item	Price
Funnel cake	\$8
Chicken strips	\$8
Ribbon fries	\$8
Funnel cake	\$6

Example. Based on an old match-makers rule, the socially “acceptable” minimum age of someone you can date is half your age plus seven. Make a function that takes your age, x , and finds the minimum age of someone you can date, y .

Example. Create a table to represent a function that takes each month and returns the number of days (in a non-leap year).

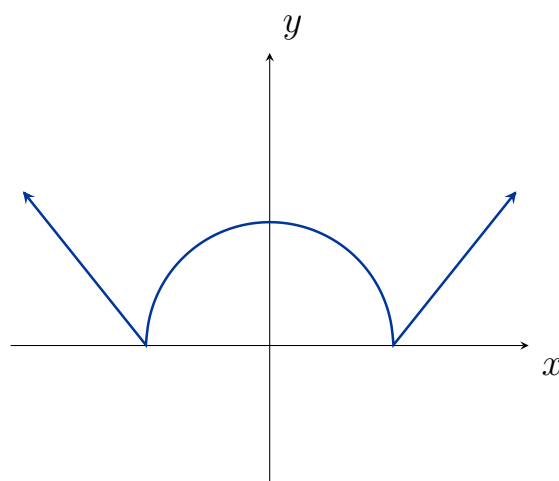
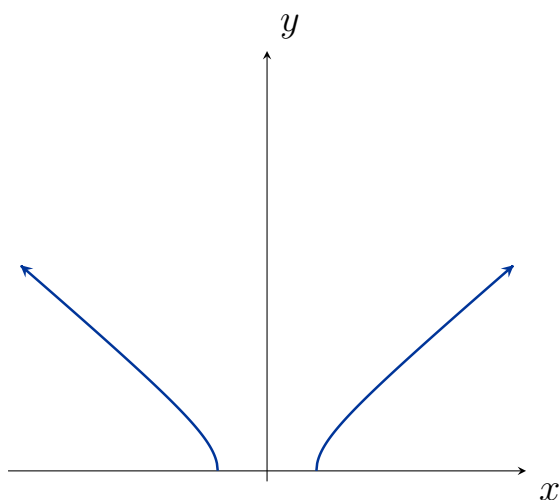
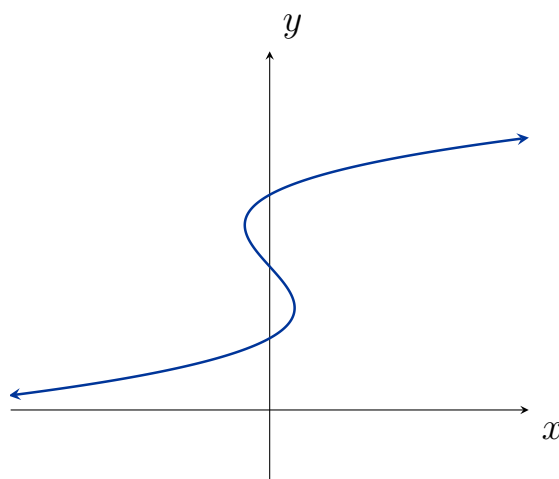
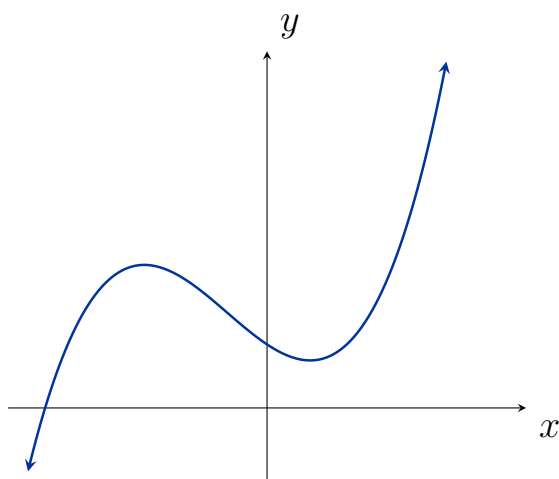
Example. If possible, express the relationship $2n + 6p = 12$ as a function $p = f(n)$. Graph the result.

Example. If possible, express the relationship $x^2 + y^2 = 1$ as a function $y = f(x)$. Graph the result.

Definition. (Vertical Line Test)

A curve in the xy -plane is the graph of a function $y = f(x)$ (an explicit function) if and only if each vertical line intersects it in at most one point

Example. Use the vertical line test on the following graphs to determine which graphs may represent an explicit function:



Definition. (One-to-One)

The **horizontal line test** determines if every horizontal line passes through the graph of a function in at most one point.

A function is said to be **one-to-one** if each output value corresponds to *exactly* one input value (and hence passes the horizontal line test).

Example. Which of the following represent a one-to-one function?

[Graph](#)

$$y = x^2$$

$$y^2 = x$$

$$f(x) = \sqrt{x}$$

$$y = |x|$$

$$f(x) = (x + 1)(x - 1)(x - 2)$$

The equation of a circle:
 $x^2 + y^2 = 1$

The area of a circle:

$$A = \pi r^2$$

[Graphs of basic functions](#)

1.2: Domain and Range

Definition. (Interval notation)

We can specify the domain and/or range of a function using interval notation:

- Strict inequalities (exclusive) are represented using parenthesis:

$$x > 3 \iff (3, \infty) \qquad x < 9 \iff (-\infty, 9)$$

Note: Parenthesis are **always** used when an interval's end points are infinite

- Nonstrict inequalities (inclusive) are represented using square brackets:

$$7 \leq x \leq 11 \iff [7, 11]$$

- Disjoint intervals can be unioned together:

$$x \neq -2 \iff (-\infty, -2) \cup (-2, \infty)$$

- Any combination of the above can be used:

$$[-1, 1] \cup (2, 3] \cup (4, 5) \cup [6, \infty)$$



Recall that the domain is the set of all *possible* input values.

Example. Find the domain of the following functions (use interval notation): [Graphs](#)

$$f(x) = x - 3$$

$$A = \pi r^2$$

$$y = \sqrt{x - 1}$$

$$y = \frac{x + 2}{x^2 - 4}$$

$$y = \sqrt[3]{x - 4}$$

$$f(x) = \frac{\sqrt[4]{x^2 + 4}}{(x + 1)\sqrt{x - 1}}$$

Example. Identify the domain and range of the following:

[Graphs](#)

$$x(x+1)(x+2)^2, \quad x \geq -2$$

$$\sin(x)$$

$$\log(x)$$

$$2^x, \quad x \geq -1$$

Definition.

A **piecewise** function is a function with different definitions for different portions of the domain.

Example. Rewrite the following as piecewise functions:

$$|x| = \qquad \qquad \qquad \frac{x}{|x|} =$$

$$|x - 1| + |4 - x| =$$

Example. Graph the following piecewise function:

[Graphs](#)

$$f(x) = \begin{cases} x^2, & \text{if } x \leq 1 \\ 3, & \text{if } 1 < x \leq 2 \\ x, & \text{if } x > 2 \end{cases}$$

1.3: Rates of Change and Behavior of Graphs

Definition. (Rate of Change)

A rate of change describes how an output quantity changes relative to the change in the input quantity. The units on a rate of change are “output units per input units”. The **average rate of change** between two input values is the total change of the function values divided by the input values.

$$\frac{\Delta y}{\Delta x} = \frac{f(x_2) - f(x_1)}{x_2 - x_1}$$

Example. Suppose the following table contains temperatures recorded through the day.

h	7 AM	9 AM	11 AM	1 PM	3 PM
$T(h)$	$78^\circ F$	$81^\circ F$	$87^\circ F$	$93^\circ F$	$98^\circ F$

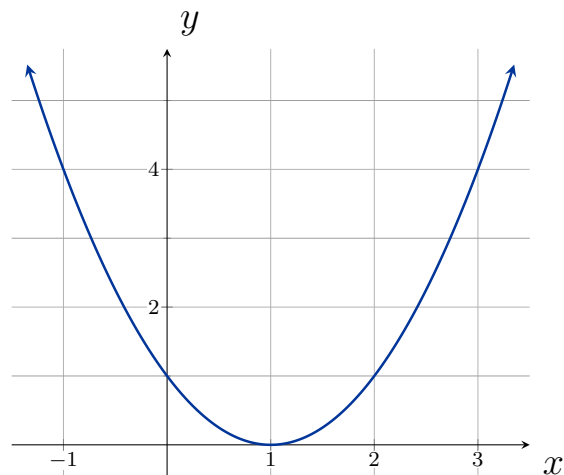
Find the average rate of change between

7 AM and 9 AM

9 AM and 11 AM

7 AM and 3 PM

Example. Using the following graph, determine the average rate of change on the interval $[-1, 2]$



Example. Find the average rate of change of $f(x) = x^2 - \frac{1}{x}$ on the interval $[2, 4]$.

Example. Find the expression for the average rate of change of $g(t) = t^2 + 3t + 1$ on the interval $[0, a]$.

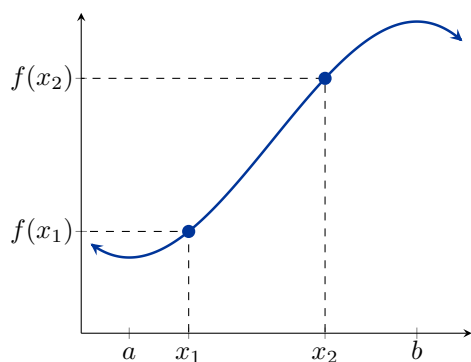
Example. Find the expression for the average rate of change of $j(t) = \frac{1}{t+3}$ on the interval $[1, 1+h]$.

Example. Find the expression for the average rate of change of $g(x) = \sqrt{x-1}$ on the interval $[x, x+h]$.

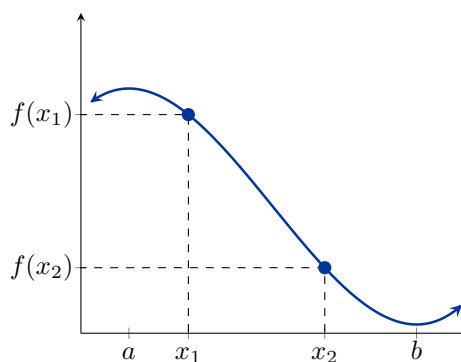
Definition.

Consider the function $f(x)$ on the interval (a, b) . Given *any* two numbers x_1 and x_2 in (a, b) where $x_1 < x_2$, we say f is

increasing if $f(x_1) < f(x_2)$



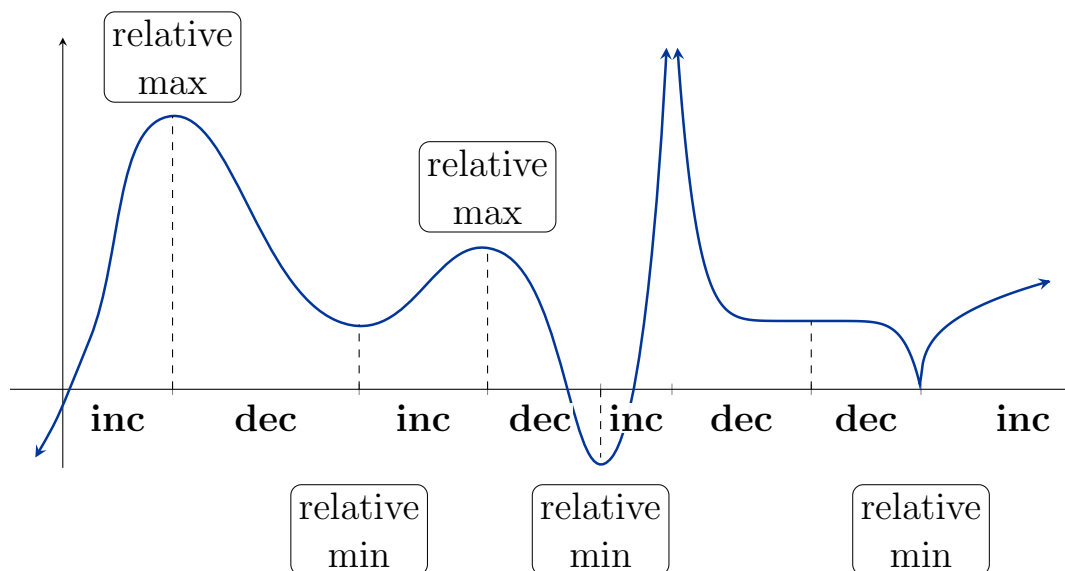
decreasing if $f(x_1) > f(x_2)$



Definition. (Relative/Local Extrema)

A function f has a

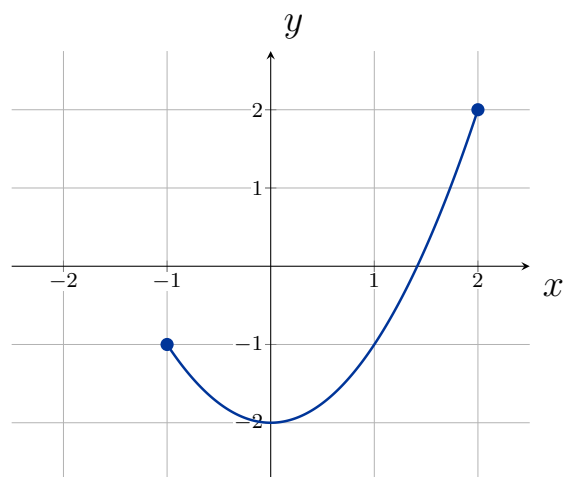
- **relative maximum** at $x = c$ if $f(c) \geq f(x)$ for every x in (a, b)
- **relative minimum** at $x = c$ if $f(c) \leq f(x)$ for every x in (a, b)

**Definition. (Absolute Extrema)**

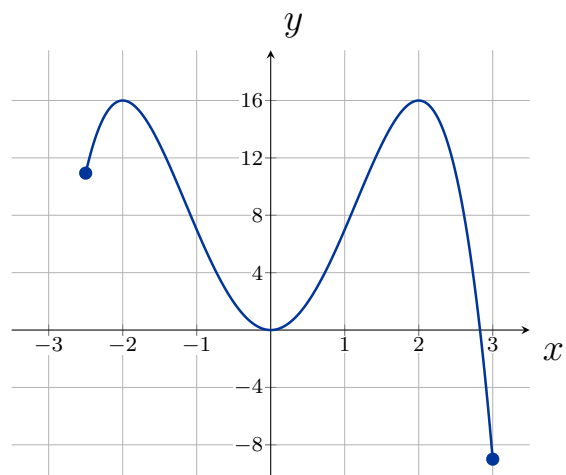
A function f defined on a domain D has an

- **absolute maximum** at $x = c$ if $f(c) \geq f(x)$ for every x in D
- **absolute minimum** at $x = c$ if $f(c) \leq f(x)$ for every x in D

Example. Using the following graph, find any relative and absolute extrema.



Example. Using the following graph, find any relative and absolute extrema.



1.4: Composition of Functions

Definition. (The Composition of Two Functions)

Let f and g be functions. Then the composition of g and f is the function $g \circ f$ defined by

$$(g \circ f)(x) = g(f(x))$$

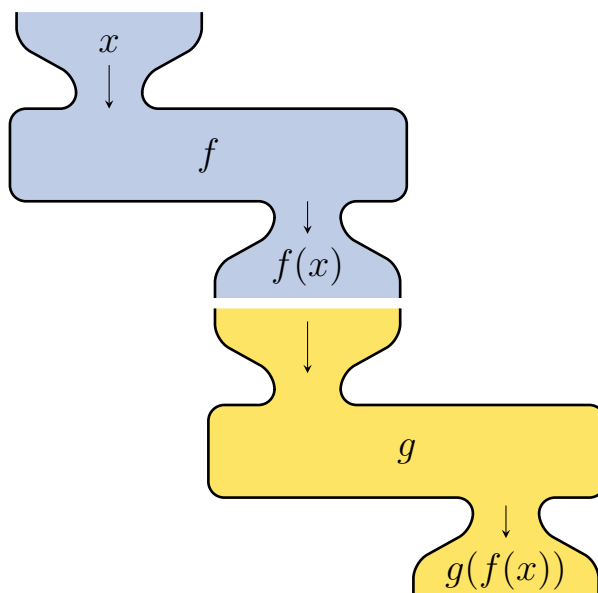
The domain of $g \circ f$ is the set of all x in the domain of f such that $f(x)$ lies in the domain of g .

Example. Let $f(x) = \sqrt{x+1}$ and $g(x) = 4 - x$. Find the domain of the following:

$$g(f(x)) =$$

$$f(g(x)) =$$

$$f(f(x)) =$$



Example. For the following, find functions $g(x)$ and $h(x)$ so that $f(x) = g(h(x))$:

$$f(x) = \frac{1}{x+2}$$

$$f(x) = \sqrt{x-4}$$

$$f(x) = (x^2 + 3x - 8)^4$$

$$f(x) = \frac{x-3}{\sqrt{-(x-3)}}$$

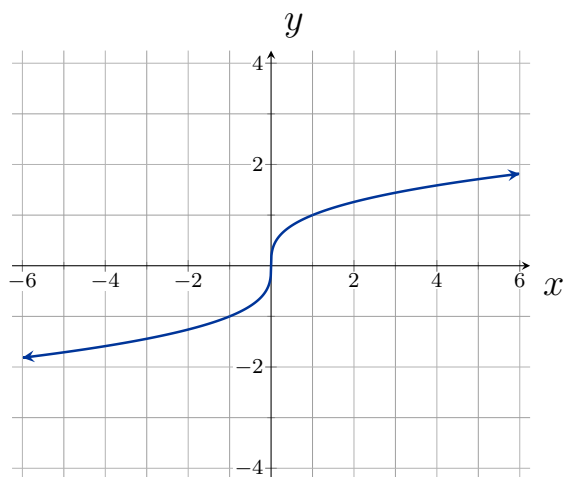
1.5: Transformation of Functions

Definition. (Vertical Shift)

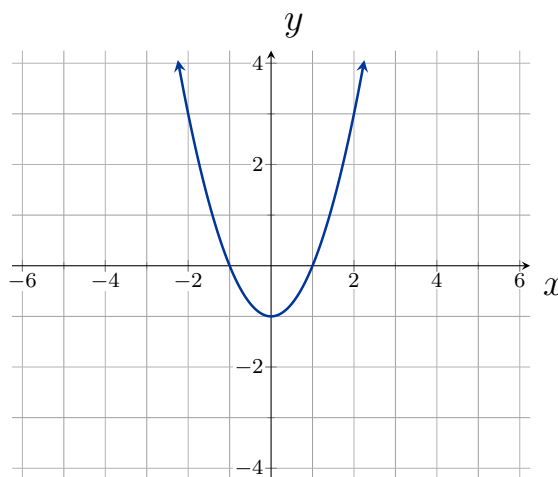
Given a function $f(x)$, a new function $g(x) = f(x) + k$, where k is a constant, is a **vertical shift** of the function $f(x)$. All the output values shift vertically by k units (**up** if $h > 0$, **down** if $h < 0$).

Example. Using the graphs below, sketch the shifted functions as indicated:

Graph $f(x) + 2$:



Graph $f(x) - 1$:

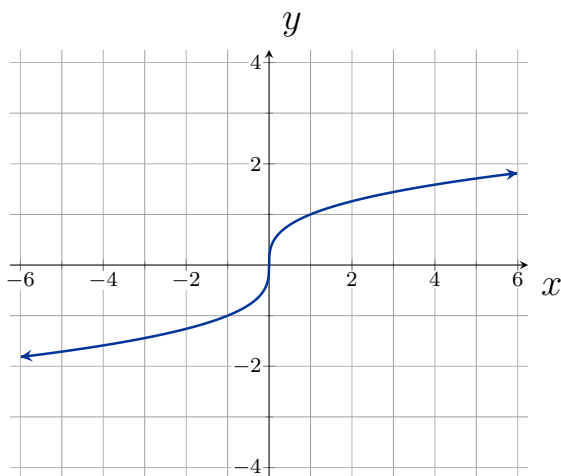


Definition. (Horizontal Shift)

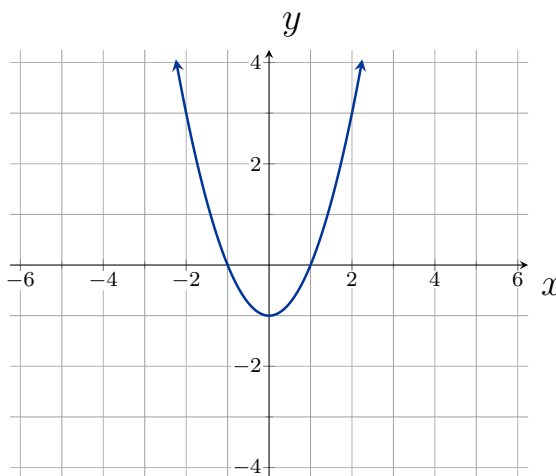
Given a function $f(x)$, a new function $g(x) = f(x - h)$, where h is a constant, is a **horizontal shift** of the function $f(x)$. All the output values shift horizontally by h units (**right** if $h > 0$, **left** if $h < 0$).

Example. Using the graphs below, sketch the shifted functions as indicated:

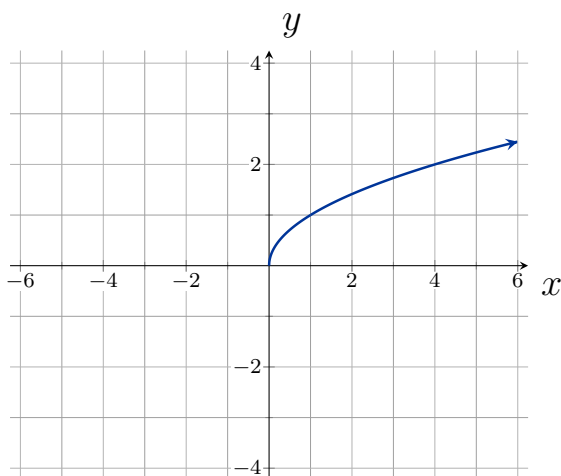
Graph $f(x + 2)$:



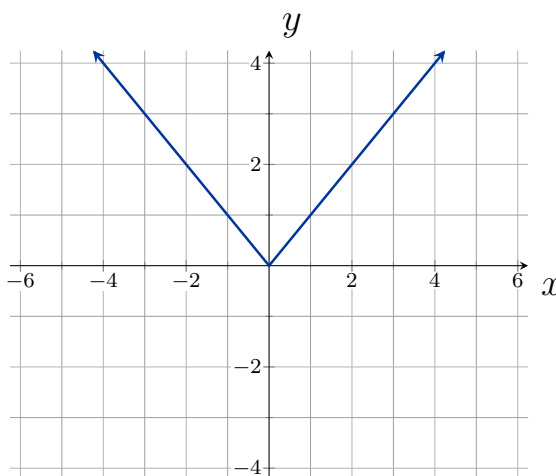
Graph $f(x - 1)$:



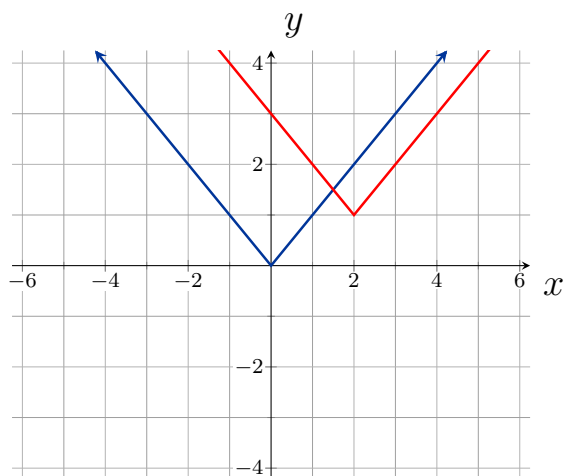
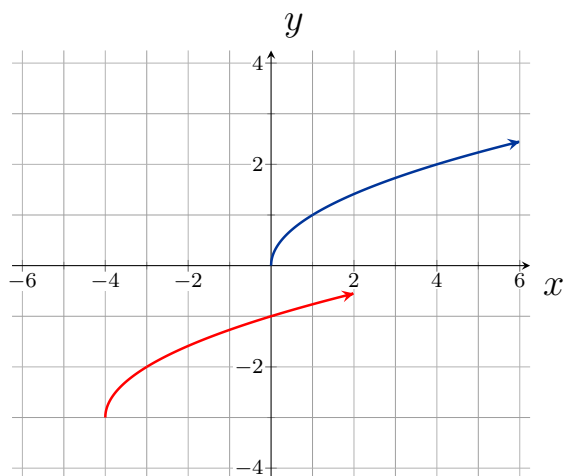
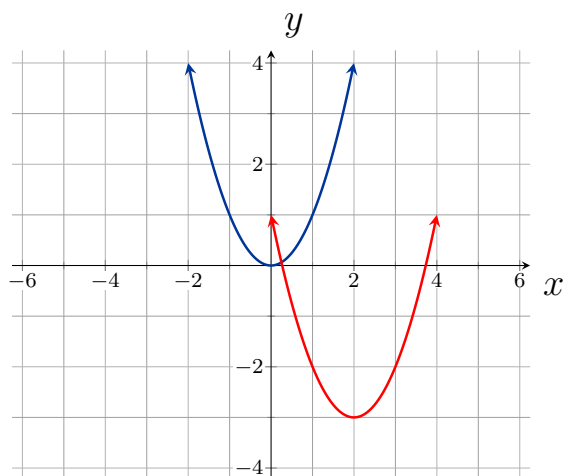
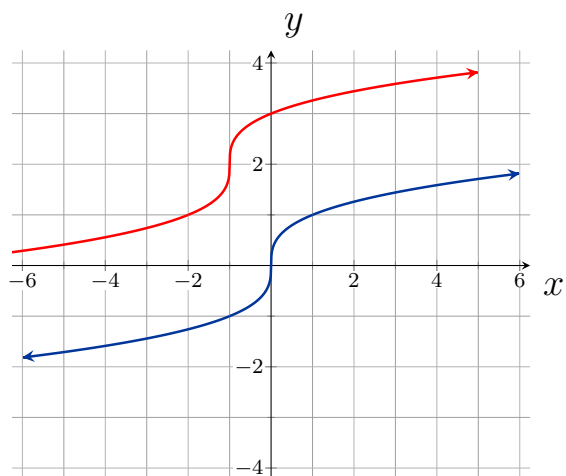
Graph $f(x - 2) + 1$:



Graph $f(x + 1) - 3$:



Example. Identify the shifts which transform the blue graph into the red graph:



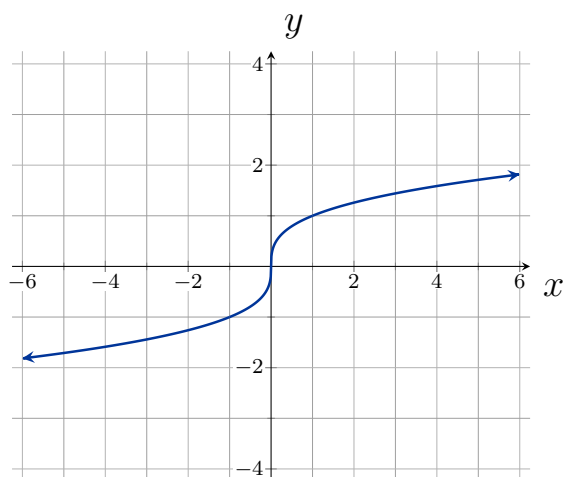
Definition. (Reflections)

Given a function $f(x)$, a new function $g(x) = -f(x)$ is a **vertical reflection** of the function $f(x)$, sometimes called a reflection about the x -axis.

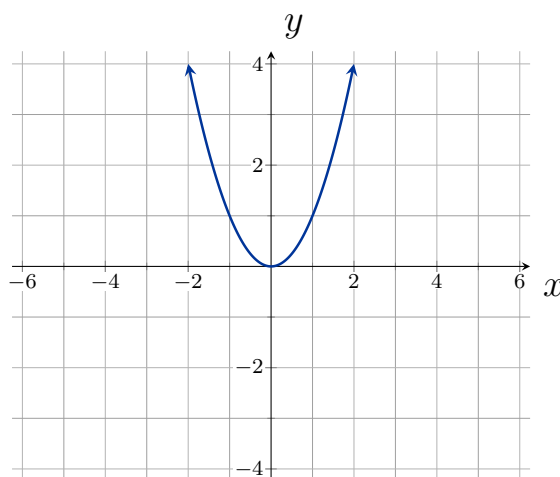
Given a function $f(x)$, a new function $g(x) = f(-x)$ is a **horizontal reflection** of the function $f(x)$, sometimes called a reflection about the y -axis.

Example. Transform the graphs below as indicated:

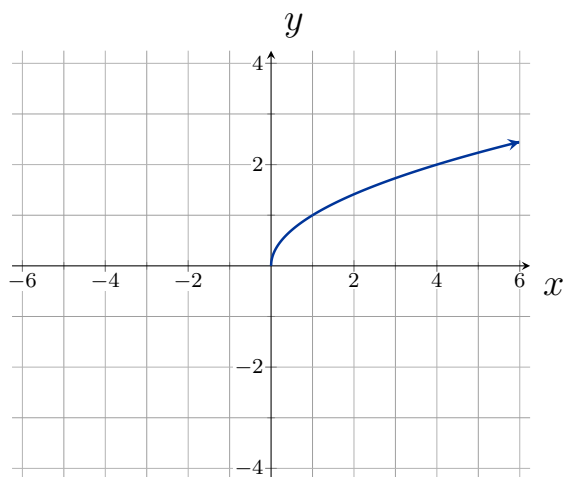
Graph $f(-x)$:



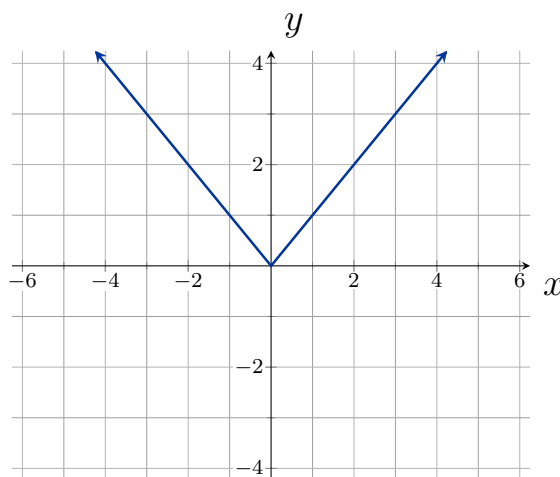
Graph $-f(x)$:



Graph $-f(-x)$:



Graph $-f(x) + 1$:



Definition. (Even and Odd functions)

A function is called an even function if for every input x

$$f(x) = f(-x)$$

The graph of an even function is symmetric about the y -axis.

A function is called an odd function if for every input x

$$f(x) = -f(-x) \quad \text{or} \quad -f(x) = f(-x)$$

The graph of an odd function is symmetric about the origin.

Example. Using algebra, determine if the following functions are even, odd, or neither:

[Graphs](#)

$$f(x) = x^3$$

$$g(x) = |x| + 1$$

$$h(x) = (x - 1)^2$$

$$j(x) = x^3 - \frac{1}{x}$$

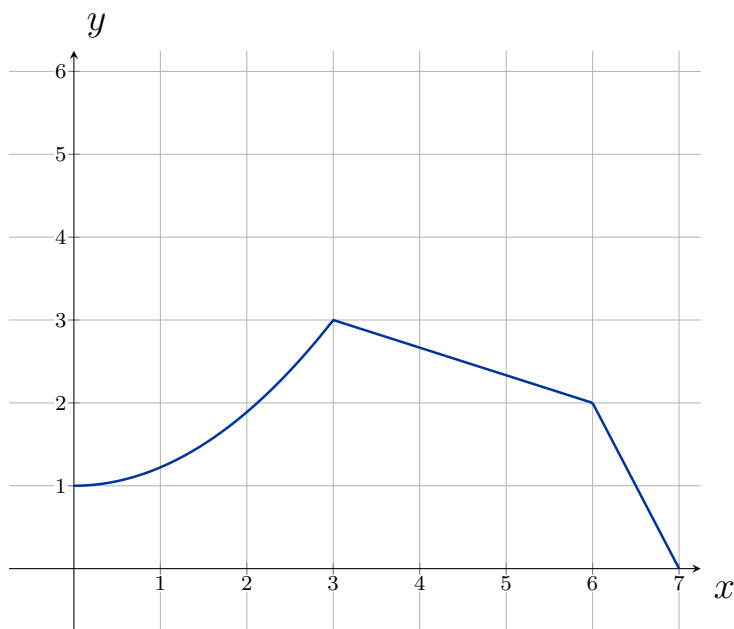
Definition. (Vertical Stretches and Compressions)

Given a function $f(x)$, a new function $g(x) = af(x)$, where a is a constant, is a **vertical stretch** or **vertical compression** of the function $f(x)$.

- If $a > 1$, then the graph will be stretched.
- If $0 < a < 1$, then the graph will be compressed.
- If $a < 0$, then there will be a combination of a vertical stretch/compression with a vertical reflection.

Example. Given the graph of $f(x)$ below, graph $g(x) = 2f(x)$:

[Graphs](#)



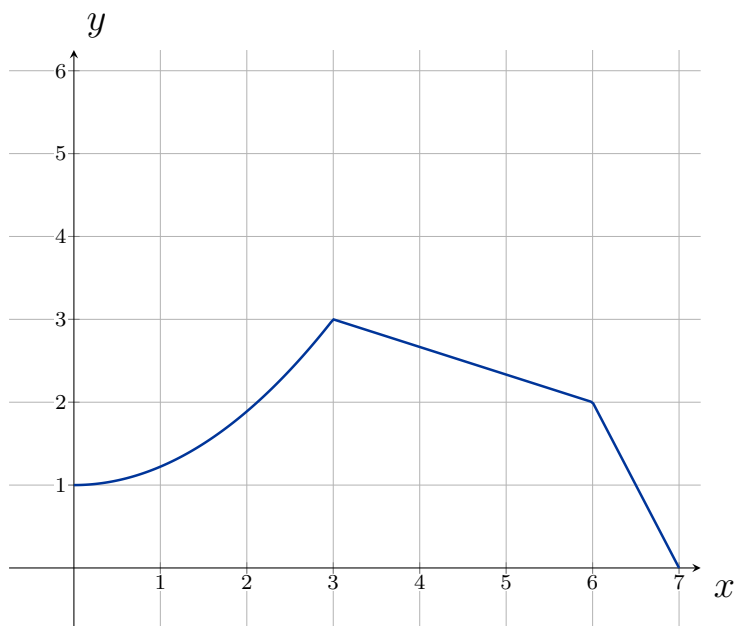
Definition. (Horizontal Stretches and Compressions)

Given a function $f(x)$, a new function $g(x) = f(bx)$, where b is a constant, is a **horizontal stretch** or **horizontal compression** of the function $f(x)$.

- If $b > 1$, then the graph will be stretched by $\frac{1}{b}$.
- If $0 < b < 1$, then the graph will be compressed by $\frac{1}{b}$.
- If $b < 0$, then there will be a combination of a horizontal stretch/compression with a horizontal reflection.

Example. Given the graph of $f(x)$ below, graph $g(x) = f(2x)$:

[Graphs](#)



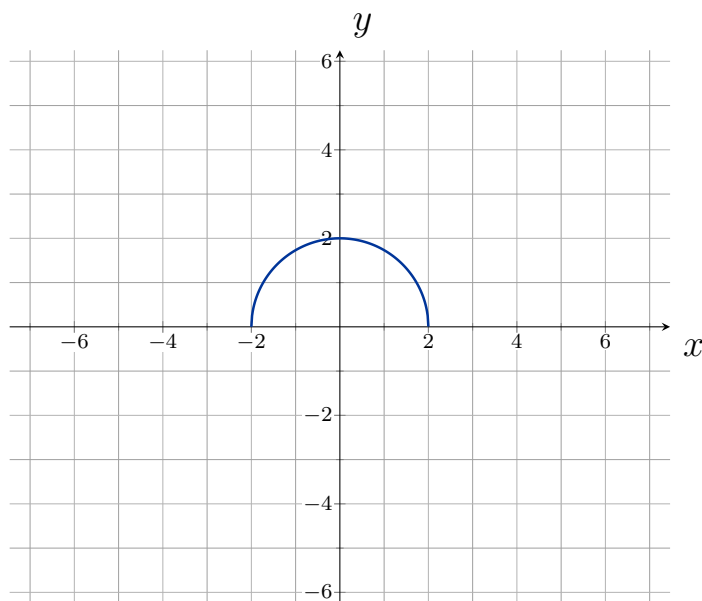
Combining Transformations

When combining transformations ...

- $af(x) + k$: first vertically stretch by a and then shift by k .
- $f(bx - h)$: first horizontally shift by h and then horizontally stretch by $\frac{1}{b}$.
- $f(b(x - h))$: first horizontally stretch by $\frac{1}{b}$ and then horizontally shift by h .
- Horizontal and vertical transformations are independent of the order they are performed.

Example. Given the graph of $f(x)$ below, graph $g(x) = f\left(\frac{1}{2}x + 1\right) - 3$:

[Graphs](#)



1.6: Absolute Value Functions

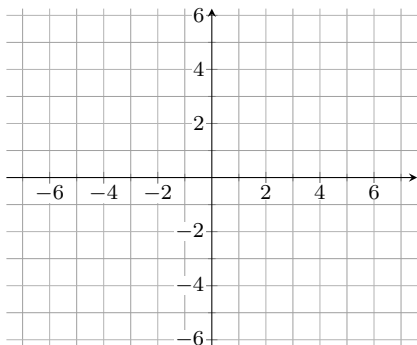
Definition. (Absolute Value Function)

The absolute value function can be defined as a piecewise function

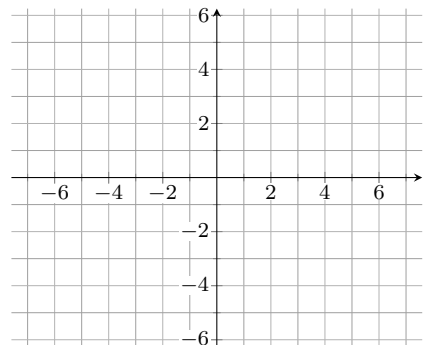
$$f(x) = |x| = \begin{cases} x, & \text{if } x \geq 0 \\ -x, & \text{if } x < 0 \end{cases}$$

Example. Graph the following

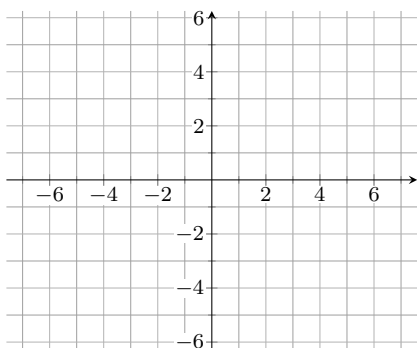
$$f(x) = |x|$$



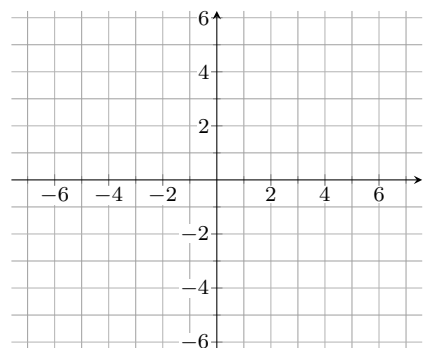
$$f(x) = |x - 2|$$



$$f(x) = |x| + 3$$



$$f(x) = 2|x - 3| + 1$$



Example. Solve the following equations

[Graphs](#)

$$|x| = 3$$

$$|2x + 6| = 2$$

$$|x + 3| - 1 = 0$$

$$2 - |4 - x| = 0$$

Example. Solve the following inequalities. Give your answer in interval notation. [Graphs](#)

$$|x - 5| \leq 4$$

$$\left| \frac{x}{4} - 1 \right| < 2$$

$$|2 - x| \leq 3$$

$$|x - 3| > 2$$

2.1: Linear Functions

Definition. (Slope of a Nonvertical Line)

If (x_1, y_1) and (x_2, y_2) are any two distinct points on a nonvertical line L , then the slope m of L is given by

$$m = \frac{\Delta y}{\Delta x} = \frac{y_2 - y_1}{x_2 - x_1}$$

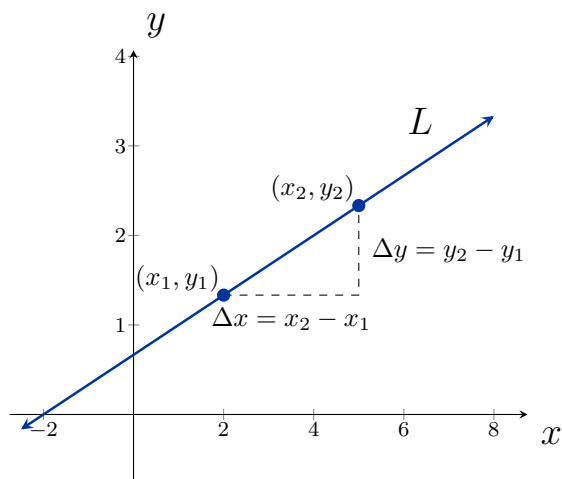
Example. Compute the slope of the line passing through the points

$$(x_1, y_1) = (1, 1) \text{ and } (x_2, y_2) = (4, 2)$$

$$(x_1, y_1) = (3, -1) \text{ and } (x_2, y_2) = (-2, 8)$$

$$(x_1, y_1) = (3, 2) \text{ and } (x_2, y_2) = (-1, 2)$$

$$(x_1, y_1) = (4, 1) \text{ and } (x_2, y_2) = (4, 4)$$



Definition. (Point-Slope Form of an Equation of a Line)

An equation of the line that has slope m and passes through the point (x_1, y_1) is given by

$$y - y_1 = m(x - x_1)$$

Example. Find the equation of the line going through the points

$$(x_1, y_1) = (-2, 1) \text{ and } (x_2, y_2) = (3, -2)$$

$$(x_1, y_1) = (3, 4) \text{ and } (x_2, y_2) = (-1, 4)$$

$$(x_1, y_1) = (2, 0) \text{ and } (x_2, y_2) = (2, 1)$$

Definition. (Slope-Intercept Form of an Equation of a Line)

An equation of the line that has slope m and intersects the y -axis at the point $(0, b)$ is given by

$$y = mx + b$$

Example. Rewrite the equations in the previous example in slope-intercept form.

Example. Marcus currently has 200 songs in his music collection. Every month, he adds 15 new songs. Write a formula for the number of songs, N , in his collection as a function of time, t , the number of months. How many songs will he own in a year?

Forms of Linear Equations

General form: $Ax + By = C$

Point-slope form: $y - y_1 = m(x - x_1)$

Slope-intercept form: $y = mx + b$

Vertical line: $x = a$

Horizontal line: $y = b$

2.2: Graphs of Linear Functions

Definition. (Parallel and Perpendicular lines)

Let L_1 and L_2 be lines with slopes m_1 and m_2 respectively. If L_1 and L_2 are *parallel*, then

$$m_1 = m_2.$$

If L_1 and L_2 are *perpendicular*, then

$$m_1 = -\frac{1}{m_2}.$$

Example.

Find the line *parallel* to $y = \frac{3}{2}x + 1$ that passes through the point $(-4, 10)$.

Find the line *perpendicular* to $y = \frac{3}{2}x + 1$ that passes through the point $(-3, 4)$.

Definition.

The point(s) where a graph intersects the axes are called intercepts.

The **x -intercepts** are the points where a function intersects the x -axis.

The **y -intercept** is the point where a function intersects the y -axis.

- To solve for the y -intercept:
 - Set $x = 0$,
 - Solve for y .
- To solve for the x -intercept:
 - Set $y = 0$,
 - Solve for x .

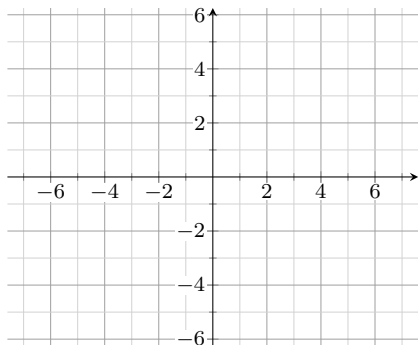
Example. Find the x and y intercepts of the following:

$$y = \frac{4}{5}x - 8$$

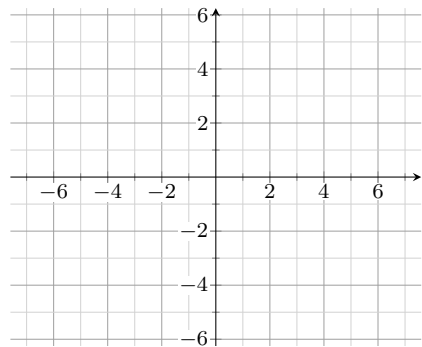
$$3x + 2y = 18$$

Example. Graph the following:

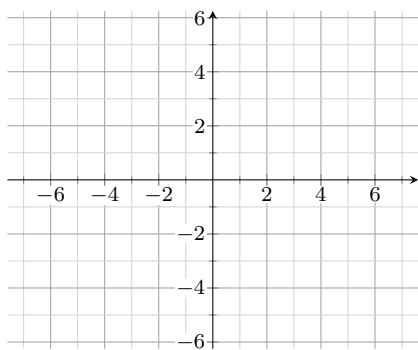
$$y = -\frac{3}{2}x + 3$$



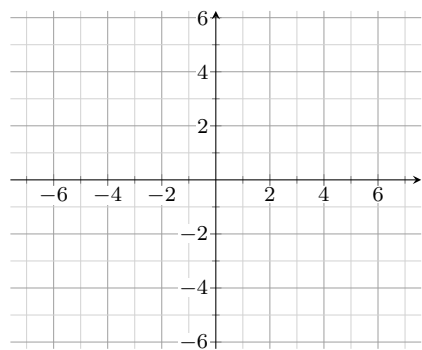
The line through $(-4, 2)$ and $(1, 4)$



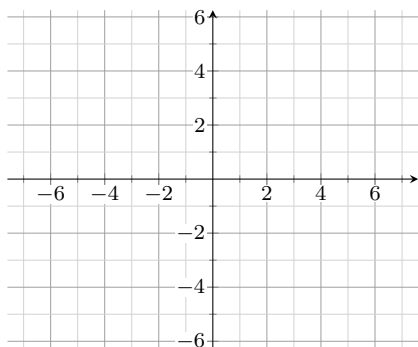
The horizontal line through $(2, 3)$



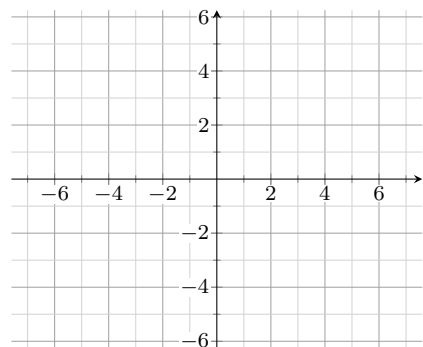
The vertical line through $(-1, 5)$



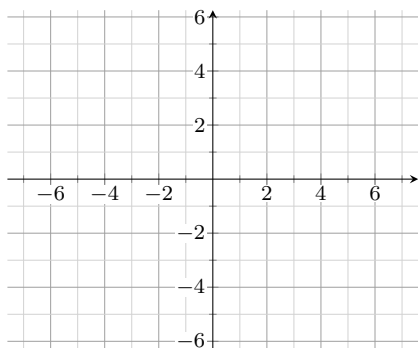
$$8x - 10y = 40$$



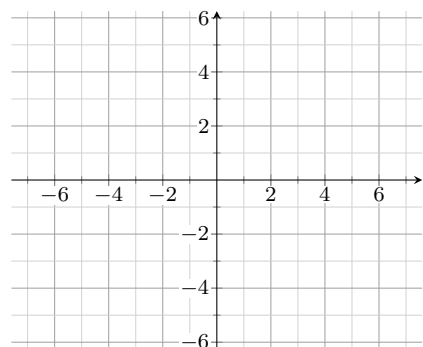
$$y = -4x - 5$$



Through $(1, 1)$, parallel to $y = 2x - 4$



Through $(3, -2)$, perp. to $y = \frac{1}{3}x - 1$

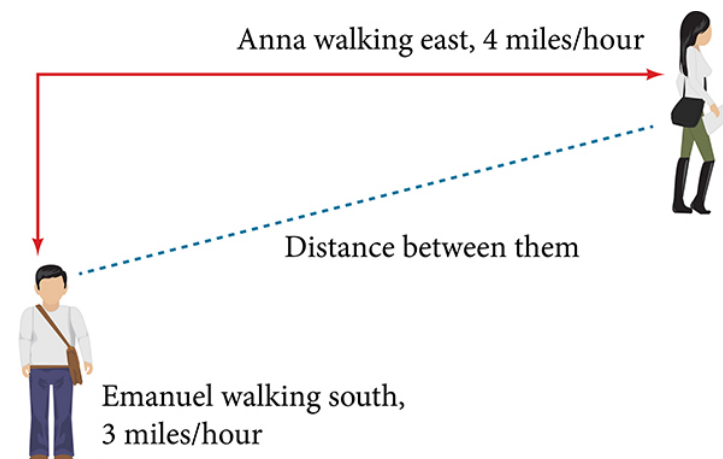


2.3: Modeling with Linear Functions

Example. Elan is a college student who plans to spend a summer in Seattle. Elan has saved \$3,500 for the trip and anticipates spending \$400 each week on rent, food, and activities. Write a linear model to represent this scenario. Identify and interpret:

- the rate of change
- the initial amount
- the x -intercept

Example. Anne and Emanuel start at the same intersection. Anna walks east at 4 miles per hour while Emanuel walks south at 3 miles per hour. They are communicating with a two-way radio that has a range of 2 miles. How long after they start walking will they fall out of radio contact?



Example. Jamal is choosing between two truck-rental companies. The first, *Keep on Trucking, Inc.*, charges an up-front fee of \$20, then 59 cents a mile. The second, *Move It Your Way*, charges an up-front fee of \$16, then 63 cents a mile. When will *Keep on Trucking, Inc.* be the better choice for Jamal?

3.1: Complex Numbers

Definition. (Imaginary and Complex Numbers)

We can extend the real numbers by defining:

$$i = \sqrt{-1}.$$

A **complex number** is a number of the form $a + bi$ where

- a is the real part of the complex number, and
- bi is the imaginary part of the complex number.

If $b = 0$, then $a + bi$ is a real number.

If $a = 0$ and $b \neq 0$, then the complex number is called an **imaginary number**.

An imaginary number is an *even* root of a negative number.

$$\begin{array}{ccc} & 5 + 2i & \\ \text{real part} \nearrow & & \nwarrow \text{Imaginary part} \end{array}$$

Example. Express the following complex numbers in standard form:

$$\sqrt{-9}$$

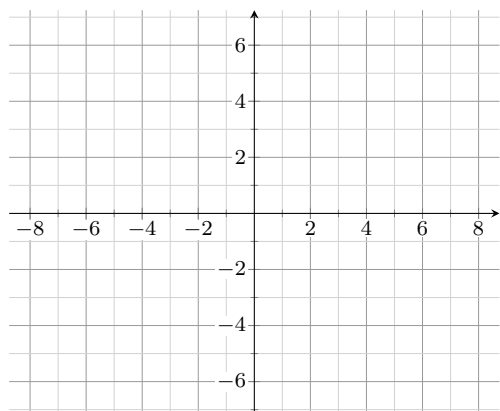
$$5 + \sqrt{-3}$$

$$4 - \sqrt{-16}$$

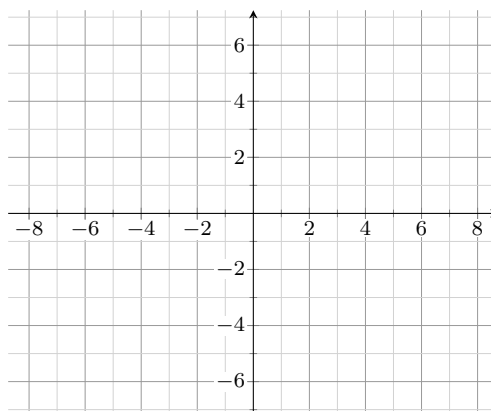
$$3 - \sqrt{25}$$

Example. Graph the following complex numbers:

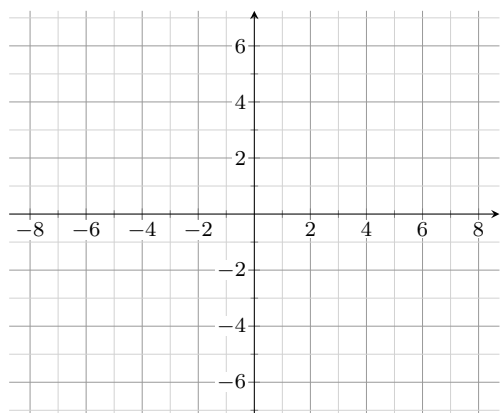
$$1 + i$$



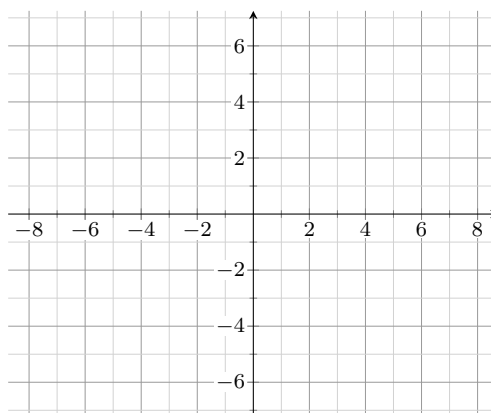
$$-2 + 3i$$



$$3 - 4i$$



$$-5 - 2i$$



Definition. (Addition and Subtraction of complex numbers)

Given complex numbers $a + bi$ and $c + di$,

$$(a + bi) + (c + di) = (a + c) + (b + d)i$$

$$(a + bi) - (c + di) = (a + c) - (b + d)i$$

Example. Evaluate the following:

$$(3 + 2i) + (1 - 4i)$$

$$(-4 - 2i) - (-1 + 5i)$$

$$(2) - (-1 + 2i)$$

$$(5i) + (3 + i)$$

Definition. (Multiplying complex numbers)

Given complex numbers $a + bi$ and $c + di$,

$$\begin{aligned}(a + bi) \cdot (c + di) &= ac + adi + bci + bdi^2 \\ &= ac + adi + bci - bd \\ &= (ac - bd) + (ad + bc)i\end{aligned}$$

Example. Evaluate the following:

$$(3 + 2i) \cdot (1 - 4i)$$

$$(-4 - 2i) \cdot (-1 + 5i)$$

$$(2) \cdot (-1 + 2i)$$

$$(5i) \cdot (3 + i)$$

Definition. (Dividing complex numbers)

Given complex numbers $a + bi$ and $c + di$, division is done via the *complex conjugate*:

$$\begin{aligned}\frac{c + di}{a + bi} \cdot \frac{a - bi}{a - bi} &= \frac{(c + di)(a - bi)}{(a + bi)(a - bi)} \\ &= \frac{ac - bci + adi - bdi^2}{a^2 - abi + abi - b^2i^2} \\ &= \frac{(ac + bd) + (ad - bc)i}{a^2 + b^2}\end{aligned}$$

Example. Evaluate the following:

$$\frac{3 + 2i}{1 - 4i}$$

$$\frac{-4 - 2i}{-1 + 5i}$$

$$\frac{2}{-1 + 2i}$$

$$\frac{3 + i}{5i}$$

Example. Given $f(x) = x^2 - 5x + 2$, evaluate $f(3 + i)$.

Example. Given $f(x) = \frac{2 + x}{x + 3}$, evaluate $f(10i)$.

Example. Find i raised to different powers: $i, i^2, i^3, \dots$, then evaluate i^{35} .

3.2: Quadratic functions

Definition.

A quadratic is a function of degree two. The **general form of a quadratic function** is

$$f(x) = ax^2 + bx + c \quad (a \neq 0)$$

where a , b , and c represent constants. The **standard form of a quadratic** is

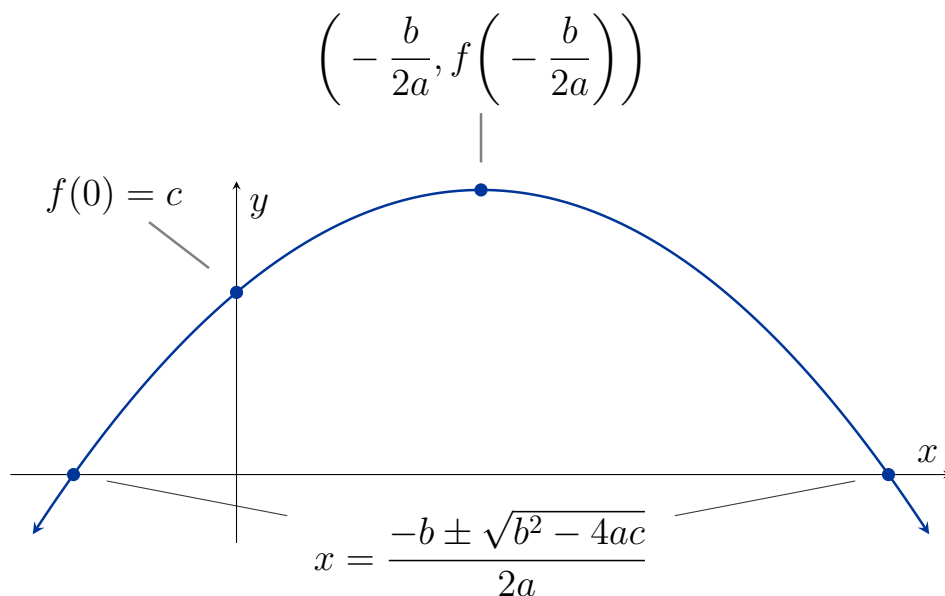
$$f(x) = a(x - h)^2 + k.$$

A **parabola** is the shape of the graph of a quadratic function, with a vertex at (h, k) :

$$h = -\frac{b}{2a}, \quad \text{and} \quad k = f(h) = c - \frac{b^2}{4a}$$

The optimal value occurs at the vertex of a parabola:

- A maximum if $a < 0$ 
- A minimum if $a > 0$ 



Example. Find the vertex of the following quadratic functions by

- computing h and k , and
- rewriting the quadratic in standard form by completing the square.

Identify if the vertex is the maximum or minimum value.

$$f(x) = 2x^2 - 6x + 7$$

$$g(x) = 13 - 3x^2 + 4x$$

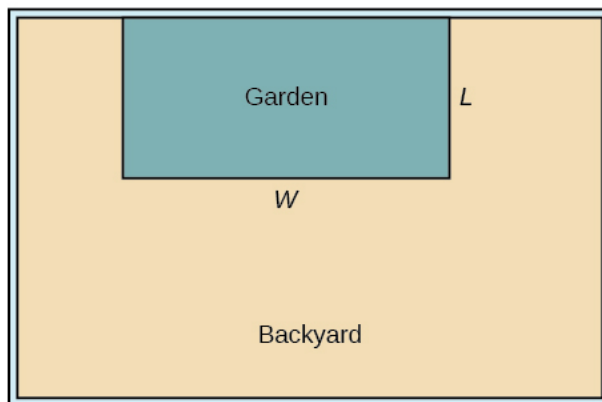
Example. For the following quadratic functions, find

- the x and y -intercepts,
- the vertex, and
- the domain and range.

$$f(x) = 3x^2 + 2x - 4$$

$$g(x) = -(x + 2)^2 - 1$$

Example. A backyard farmer wants to enclose a rectangular space for a new garden within her fenced backyard. She has purchased 80 feet of wire fencing to enclose three sides, and she will use a section of the backyard fence as the fourth side (see below). What dimensions should she use to maximize the enclosed area?



3.3: Power Functions and Polynomial Functions

Definition. (Power Function)

A **power function** is a function that can be represented in the form

$$f(x) = kx^p$$

where k and p are real numbers, and k is known as the **coefficient**.

Example. Identify which of the following functions are power functions:

$f(x) = 1$

Constant

$f(x) = x$

Identity

$f(x) = x^2$

Quadratic

$f(x) = x^3$

Cubic

$f(x) = \frac{1}{x}$

Reciprocal

$f(x) = \frac{1}{x^2}$

Reciprocal squared

$f(x) = \sqrt{x}$

Square root

$f(x) = \sqrt[3]{x}$

Cube root

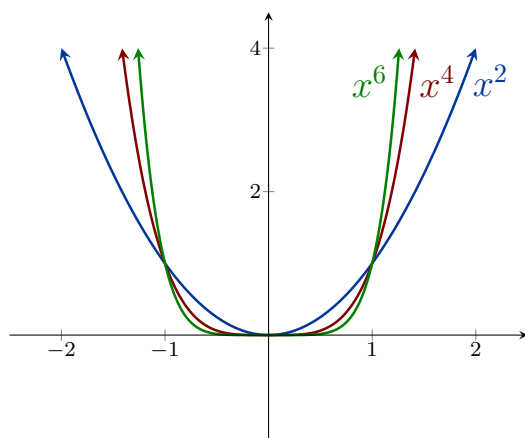
$f(x) = 2^x$

Exponential

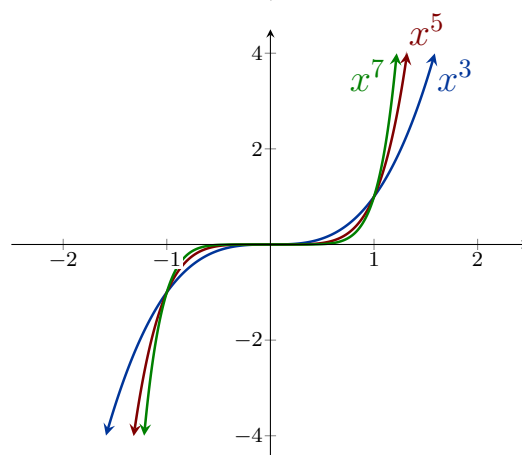
Identifying End Behavior of Power Functions

Below are example graphs of power functions $f(x) = kx^n$:

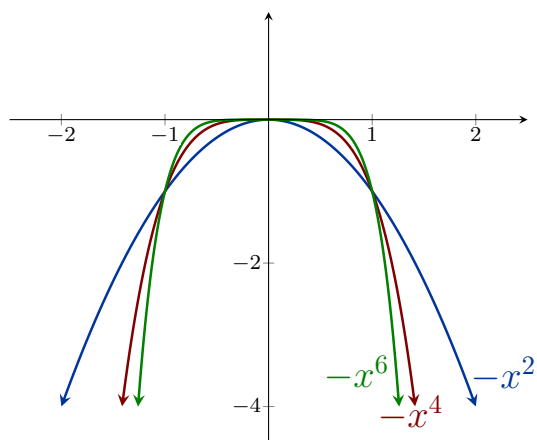
n Even, $k > 0$



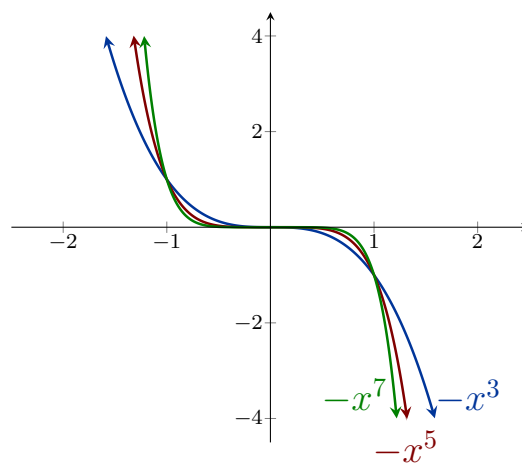
n Odd, $k > 0$



n Even, $k < 0$



n Odd, $k < 0$



Example. Describe the end behavior of the graphs of the following power functions:

$$f(x) = x^8$$

$$g(x) = -x^9$$

Definition. (Polynomial Functions)

Let n be a non-negative integer. A **polynomial function** is a function that can be written in the form

$$f(x) = a_n x^n + a_{n-1} x^{n-1} + \cdots + a_2 x^2 + a_1 x + a_0$$

Each a_i is a coefficient and can be any real number, and $a_n \neq 0$.

The **degree** of the polynomial is the highest power that the variable is raised to. The **leading coefficient** is the coefficient associated with the term containing the highest power of the variable.

Example. Describe the end behavior of the graphs of the following polynomials: [Graphs](#)

$$f(x) = 5x^4 + 2x^3 - x - 4$$

$$g(x) = -2x^6 - x^5 + 3x^4 + x^3$$

$$h(x) = 3x^5 - 4x^4 + 2x^2 + 1$$

$$j(x) = -6x^3 + 7x^2 + 3x + 1$$

Definition. (Intercepts and Turning Points of Polynomial Functions)

A **turning point** is a point at which the graph changes direction from increasing to decreasing, or decreasing to increasing.

The y -intercept is the point at which the function has an input value of zero.

The x -intercepts are the points at which the output value is zero.

A polynomial of degree n will have, at most, n x -intercepts, and $n - 1$ turning points.

Complex Conjugate Root Theorem

If a polynomial $f(x)$ has real coefficients, and $a + bi$ is a root of $f(x)$, then $a - bi$ is also a root of $f(x)$.

Example. Find the intercepts of

$$f(x) = x^4 - 4x^2 - 45$$